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COVER STORY

KATE & WILLIAM

THE CROWN IS IN YOUR HANDS

WHILE THE UNITED KINGDOM TRIES TO RECOVER FROM YET ANOTHER SCANDAL THAT HAS OVERWHELMED THE WINDSORS, ONLY TWO WINNING HORSES REMAIN AT BUCKINGHAM PALACE: THE PRINCE AND PRINCESS OF WALES. MORALLY UNASSAILABLE BUT ALSO CLOSE TO THE PEOPLE, THEY ARE A "COUPLE OF STEEL" CAPABLE OF SOFTENING HEARTS AND INSPIRING PRIDE.

Text by Luisa Ciuni

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KATE MIDDLETON BORN IN READING ON JANUARY 9, 1982, SHE STUDIED ART HISTORY AT ST. ANDREWS UNIVERSITY IN SCOTLAND WHERE, IN 2001, SHE MET WILLIAM. THE COUPLE MARRIED ON APRIL 29, 2011, ASSUMING THE TITLE OF PRINCE AND PRINCESS OF WALES.

From "commoner," as the tabloids called her with contempt, to the applause for "Brave Kate," Princess of Wales and future of the crown navigating in stormy waters. What will be the new label for Catherine Middleton? What will be her future and that of William and their three children George, Charlotte, and Louis? Can the Prince of Wales survive the disaster of Andrew, the profound crisis marking the reign of Charles III, and the search for new strength among the Windsors to face continuous revelations from the Epstein files? A weight not easily carried on the shoulders of this 42-year-old woman, who entered the royal scene in silence 15 years ago and is now the protagonist of a slow revolution.

NO BABYSITTER

If palace life still reflects the image of an aristocratic society dedicated to hunting and horse racing, the environment of William and Kate is fresh, sporty, ecological, similar to that of the great Northern European dynasties so admired by William. No valets, no ceremonial, no bows. In Norfolk, where the Princes of Wales have their country home, Kate cooks personally, has no babysitter, and the service staff is kept to a minimum. In the worst moments of chemotherapy, when they lived in the small, beloved Adelaide Cottage, she didn't even want help to entertain the children; she

called her mother Carole for support. Because she never accepted that her children should be raised by strangers, as is the custom in the aristocracy. Her game is to combine royal splendor with everyday life. Her role is to make the greatness of Elizabeth perceived with her jewelry and haute couture clothes, but she makes herself felt like one of them in the countless visits to schools, hospitals, and factories. Thus, four years after the death of the sovereign, we see that Catherine has abandoned the rigid codes of elegance, such as raised hair and hats. She has loose hair, loafers, and trousers, and sits with agility next to children or to discuss with war veterans. William too has learned the lesson of her simplicity.

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ARISTOCRACY OF THE SPIRIT

But it's not just a matter of look. Because Catherine has at the center of her universe two missions she cares about deeply. The first is that of children's health in early childhood, a topic she has been committed to for many years. The second is the dissemination of cancer care and the encouragement of patients she has dealt with since her 2024 illness. Day after day, since she got married, she has imposed her battle for children on the government. She hasn't been able to prevent cuts to the healthcare system, but she has increased her work to raise more funds for fragile children. Support for cancer patients is developed through visits and messages that have a large following. The video in which she announces her remission is one of the most viewed in Great Britain. And the affectionate images of her and William lying on the grass on a plaid blanket caused a sensation for their nonchalance. Royals lying down together? Never seen before. They were liked. A daily "moral suasion," therefore, in place for years and which today is asked to rehabilitate the Windsors from the Epstein scandal.

THE POWER OF INTEGRITY

A restyling that is difficult to say the least, which Charles and Camilla cannot do, and on which the future of the Princes of Wales and their children depends. But the two young royals were not idle. As soon as the scandal exploded, they pressured Charles to expel his brother from the family circle and relegate him to a distant and hard-to-reach house. Then they showed solidarity with Epstein's victims and excluded Kate from the family circle of cousins Beatrice and Eugenie—innocent until proven otherwise, but often brought by Epstein to his islands by their mother Sarah Ferguson, who was also distanced. William, furthermore, is pressuring Charles to exclude Andrew from his position as Councilor of State and supports the popular will to exclude him from the line of succession, which, however, requires a law from Parliament and the consent of all Commonwealth countries. Catherine agrees all the

way because, as a good (ex) commoner, she senses that only an upright behavior can restore prestige to the Crown.

Kate explains her opinion calmly in the exhausting discussions involving her with her father-in-law and William who, instead, is aggressive. Kate brings things back to the right balance and makes herself heard. Because the Windsors know that she, with her knowledge of the English people and common thinking, holds the fate of the dynasty in her hands. Fortunately.

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I'M A MOTHER, THEREFORE I DROWN

TOO MANY RESPONSIBILITIES, TOO MUCH GUILT, "YET NO ONE AROUND SEEMS TO NOTICE": THE WORDS OF A WOMAN WHO IS A MOTHER TWICE OVER—IN REAL LIFE AND IN A FILM THAT TELLS THE STORY OF MOTHERHOOD WITHOUT DISCOUNTS. AND THAT, FINALLY, SETS US FREE. EVEN TO RUN LIKE TOM CRUISE.

Text by Enrica Brocardo

"MOTHERS ARE SIMULTANEOUSLY VENERATED AND IGNORED. It is difficult to talk about motherhood, because if you feel something other than pure joy, a sense of shame kicks in." Rose Byrne is talking about Linda, her character in the film *If Only I Could Kick You*, for which she first won a Silver Bear at the Berlinale in 2025, then a Golden Globe last January, in addition to earning an Oscar nomination for Best Actress in a Leading Role.

The 46-year-old Australian, married to colleague Bobby Cannavale since 2012, Byrne is herself a mother of two children: Rocco, 10, and Rafa, 8. An actress since she was a girl, she was the star of the 2011 comedy *Bridesmaids* and more recently played the historic leader of the American feminist movement Gloria Steinem in the series *Mrs. America*, alongside Cate Blanchett.

If Only I Could Kick You is inspired by the true story of the film's screenwriter and director, Mary Bronstein, who years ago found herself living for eight months in a hotel room, she and her daughter seriously ill. "My husband had stayed to work in New York," Mary recounted, "I was alone with my child in California, where she could receive the care she needed. I didn't do all the crazy things Linda does in the film but, like her, I would binge on junk food in secret and gulp down cheap wine. The emotional stress was terrible."

"It is a story that is unique, extreme, and universal at the same time," Byrne says during our meeting at the Rome Film Fest last October. "One of my best friends, after seeing the film, told me: 'I felt understood for the first time!'"

Why did she feel understood? It's what many of us thought. Even those who don't have sick children

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don't have children at all. Because the film talks about the feeling of being overwhelmed, of when you feel like you're drowning while no one around seems to notice. Furthermore, Linda, at this point in the story, is no longer a mother; she is a sort of caregiver, and this is a universal role that anyone of us takes on at a certain point in life. But I was surprised by the fact that even the young audience identified with the emotional state of the protagonist. For Mary, the director, it's a very personal story, but we discussed it at length together. For over a month, from Monday to Friday, after taking the kids to school, I would go to her house. Each time we would sit at her kitchen table and talk for hours. She shared her diaries with me, and I told her about my experience as a parent, the relationship with my mother, and a lot of other things. In that period, we also established who Linda was *before*. Meaning, before meeting her husband, before becoming a mother.

Has being a mother changed you a lot? There is a clear line that separates the "before" and the "after." For me, it was like landing on another planet. And I didn't know that would happen: nothing can prepare you for the birth of a child. No book, no conversation... Except perhaps someone telling you: "Forget about being prepared." Only recently have mothers begun to admit to not being 100% happy in every single moment of their role. You can feel frustrated, even angry with your own children. That idea of perfection has been dismantled through literature, cinema, and TV. Finally, space has been given to a female gaze and to the ambivalence that we all feel. But it took many years. Before, motherhood, women's feelings with sick children, their difficulties, nervous breakdowns—everything was always shown through a male lens. Things are changing and the screenplays, the female directors today, manage to find someone willing to finance this genre of film because it has been understood that we are half the population and we want to feel represented.

You have received several awards. Do these recognitions make you feel more self-confident? The world of cinema is a very tough environment. I've seen brilliant careers falter; it can happen at any moment. All we have is the experience of the moment and our choices. And the "no's" we say are more important than the "yes's." I am an executive producer of the film and I try to do my best to produce more, so as to

have more control over my work, but the truth is you never know in advance the reaction of the audience.

You started acting very young. What led you to acting? I started with small children's programs in Sydney. Then I was noticed for a film in Australia and started working when I was still a teenager, but I continued school and went to university. I didn't grow up in the spotlight like some child actors in the United States. I am grateful for the career I've managed to build. It's also a matter of luck, of timing. But every time I face a new project I am nervous, I'm afraid, and I think that if these feelings were to vanish, it would mean that for me it's time to hang up my shoes.

How do you face moments of crisis as a mother? My parents always had a great sense of humor, even in difficult moments and—it will sound cliché—they are grateful for what they have. It's the only way. Being a parent is the most demanding role because it immediately puts you in front of all your limits and flaws. The fact that children teach you so much is not just a platitude. It really is like that: they force you to do a soul-searching exam: how do I manage life, my anxieties? What are my defense mechanisms?

One last question, a bit silly if I may. There is a scene in which you run exactly like Tom Cruise. Did you do it on purpose? I love seeing him at the cinema when he runs; I gladly accept the comparison! But the truth is that the director told me: "You have to go as fast as possible." And, apparently, that is the only way to do it (*laughs*).